STATE SCAN

BIHAR: NITISH MAPS A PATH *PG 19*

GUJARAT: PATIDAR POWER DAUGHTER *PG 23*



ANI

TAKING CHARGE
Yumnam Khemchand Singh (right) becomes Manipur's 13th CM; below, Deputy CMs Losii Dikho (left) and Nemcha Kipgen





▶ MANIPUR

A CROWN OF THORNS

Chief minister: Khemchand, a Meitei and a Biren critic. Two deputy CMs: one Kuki, one Naga. Can this 'dialogue-shaped' government heal Manipur?

By **Kaushik Deka**

YUMNAM KHEMCHAND SINGH has always loved odd challenges. On the morning of December 30, 2025, inside a taekwondo training hall, the 62-year-old politician stood barefoot on polished mats, his muscles taut with concentration. At an age when many of his peers were learning to live with creaking joints and pillboxes, he was submitting his body to hours of punishing drills. A few hours later, he emerged with a fifth-dan black belt, becoming the first Indian to receive the distinction from the Seoul-based Global Traditional Taekwondo Federation. Three weeks earlier, that quintessential Khemchand was to be seen on another path marked by angularity: he drove through the Naga hills of Ukhrul and Kamjong to visit Kuki-Zo villages and